how unfettered extremism poses a threat to Pakistan, its neighbors and the world, a relationship that focuses on economic and development assistance, not as an after thought, but as the necessary foundation to promote long-term growth, and a relationship that adheres to the values that both of our nations inherently share, bolstering forces of moderation, holding dear the principles of democracy, and promoting peace and prosperity throughout Pakistan.

However, recent reports of negotiations between the Government of Pakistan and tribal leaders present a challenge for the United States: How can we balance the need to engage with certain tribal leaders but still hold firm against negotiating with terrorists who will continue to fight United States and NATO troops in Afghanistan regardless of any truce? I believe we must remain steadfast in our fight against the irreconcilable forces who wish to attack our country, destabilize the region, and return Afghanistan to the oppressive, hateful regime that gave safe harbor to al-Qaeda and other terrorist elements. However, this approach will require greater cooperation between Pakistan and Afghanistan, a concerted effort to show the Pakistani people that this is not just a fight for America but also for a secure Pakistan.

The obvious first step would be to create a comprehensive United States strategy toward Pakistan. But a report released 2 weeks ago by the Government Accountability Office shows that this administration has failed to create any comprehensive interagency plan to tackle the problems of this region. Without a plan, how are we measuring, how do we measure our performance in meeting objectives? Without a plan, how do we assure the American people that their taxpayer dollars are being put to good use? Without a plan we make ourselves susceptible to agencies working at cross-purposes with each other.

And we are now seeing signs of just these dangers coming to fruition. Yesterday the GAO released proof that the funds doled out by our Government to support the fight against extremism in the region have been subject to little or not internal oversight. For example, why is the United States Government being asked to reimburse Pakistan for air defense radar maintenance? Al-Qaeda is not known to have an air force, and the purpose of these funds is to support the fight against extremists, not to boost Pakistan's conventional warfare capability. This calls into question not just the value this administration has put on these tax dollars, but the effectiveness of what they are doing to keep us safe.

It is time we learned from our Government's mistakes and move forward. Bringing stability and growth to Pakistan, winning in Afghanistan, and fulfilling vital United States national security goals are all at stake. The democratic institutions of Pakistan are our allies, and it is only through support for these institutions that we will ultimately serve the Pakistani people and gain their cooperation in our mutual fight against extremism.

I look forward to hearing the testimonies of our three distinguished witnesses. But first we turn first to the ranking member of the committee, my friend Ms. Ros-Lehtinen of Florida for her opening remarks.

Ms. Ros-Lehtinen. Thank you so much, Mr. Chairman, for calling this important and timely hearing on an issue of great importance for United States interests in South and Central Asia, as well as for our security here at home.

Before I address the subject of this hearing, Mr. Chairman, I would like to note that however great the issues and partisan considerations that sometimes divide members on this committee, and in the House as a whole, ultimately our ability to make the process work and secure the public's interest rests upon our ability to trust one another. I regret that this bedrock requirement has been called into doubt in recent days. And I refer to language, as we

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